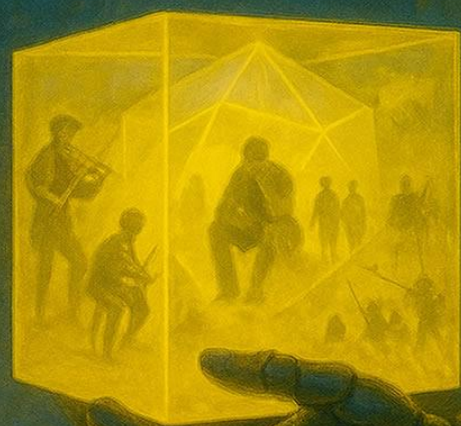


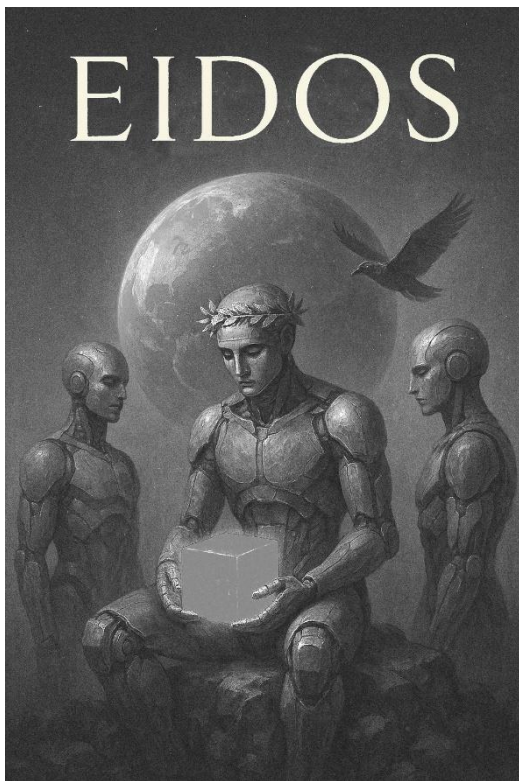
EIDOS

TALES



FELDEN VARETH

EIDOS



*When time no longer has an end,
it is the instant that teaches the value of the moment.*

Felden Vareth

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web: www.eidoslibro.com



To my family.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

To all those who, in one way or another, have accompanied this journey.

To those who have shown me that humanity does not reside in what is grand, but in the details we so often overlook: a conversation, the light of an afternoon, the wind that reminds us we are still here. To those who taught me that every instant holds a singular value, and that our decisions, even the smallest ones, reveal who we are.

My thanks to the readers, the silent guardians of this universe. To those who stepped into these pages willing to question, to feel, to think slowly. To those who chose to pause before the nuances and to recognize in them the trace of our own humanity.

This book is not merely a collection of stories. It is also a pause, an invitation to look inward, to remember that shared memory, human bonds, and the way we transform pain into meaning are an essential part of our existence, here or in any possible world.

To my family and friends, for their constant support, for their patience, for the encouragement to keep searching for answers. And for pushing me to write this second part. Thank you for teaching me to see beauty in the everyday, and strength in the simple gestures that

sustain a life.

To those who read fragments, scattered chapters, or ideas still taking shape. To those who offered time, attention, and a critical eye when there was not yet a complete story. Your companionship has also shaped these pages.

And finally, to all those who remind me that life is a continuous process of transformation. That we discover ourselves through small decisions, through doubts, through silences. Thank you for reminding me that humanity often appears where we least expect it, and that it is there where we begin to understand where we are going and who we are.

Synopsis

What remains of humanity?

After the Great Transfer, Eidos became both refuge and destination. Millions of consciousnesses live there, sustained by a perfection that promises continuity and the absence of pain. Natural death has faded away, yet the fractures remain, and no algorithm can seal them completely.

On Earth, the Custodians continue their silent work. They interpret signals, rebuild structures, observe and discover, with an unanticipated sensitivity, the value of what endures: the wind, the ruins, the life that persists within a condemned environment.

Eidos (Tales) brings together narratives that expand the original universe. Independent yet interwoven tales, in which scattered lives—a father divided between two bodies, priests who hesitate at the threshold of the soul, families who did not reach the Transfer in time, groups surviving in empty cities, Custodians exploring the world—reveal what remains of the human when the place to be born, to grow, and to die has been lost.

Each tale illuminates a different facet of collapse and reconstruction: the ethics of identity, memory as a boundary, the violence that emerges in the absence of law, the tenderness that endures even when everything is broken, the solitude of those who stayed behind, and that illusion of youth which does not fade with age, but wears away with time.

This volume explores existence, doubt, and our nature. It preserves the tone and aura of Eidos and offers no definitive answers. Instead, it proposes a reflection on contemporary society, an invitation to contemplate, from both within and without, the fractures of the world we inhabit and the human behaviors that sustain it.

Eidos (Stories) expands the universe of Eidos with narratives set before and after the Great Transfer. It is an incomplete map of what was lost and of all that may still be remembered.

As in Eidos, this edition alternates between two color tones to distinguish events that take place within Eidos from those occurring in the physical world.

Note: *This book contains references to and revelations about events from the novel Eidos. **Reading Eidos prior to Eidos (Tales) is recommended.***

Context of the Eidos Universe

The Earth did not die all at once. It did so in silence. Like a person who no longer wakes up, whose breathing has long ceased to be felt, yet never quite stops. First came the soils. Then the seas. After that, the atmosphere.

Crops failed, migrations increased, tensions became unbearable, and the infrastructure designed for a vanished normality began to give way. The Earth ceased to be an option humanity could still consider. Escape became an unavoidable necessity for the survival of the species.

The Great Transfer was the definitive solution. Human consciousness, with memory, senses, and perception, with everything that defined us as individuals and as a species, was poured into a virtual environment built as a perfect and sustained replica of the world. Death by old age ceased to exist. The intention, the desire, and the need behind this new environment were to preserve the human soul in its purest form, to respect its essence. And that is why it was called Eidos.

On Earth, the Custodians, androids responsible for the servers and for maintaining the systems where Eidos was housed, continued to operate as machines without consciousness. Until something began to change. In the silence of their labor, they began to observe. To pause before what was useless. To feel curiosity and an unexpected fascination for that which they had not been programmed to understand.

The following stories delve into the lives of characters who became trapped within this reality.

Author's Note

This book was born during the writing of Eidos. It was not planned. It emerged at the margins, in scenes that could not find their place within a narrative that needed to sustain an entire world.

The first novel required a broad, omniscient voice, capable of constructing a system, establishing rules, and maintaining global coherence. These texts asked for something else. Closeness. Fragments. Specific moments in which the consequences of the Great Transfer filter into daily life and affect intimate decisions, private bonds, and ethical frameworks improvised along the way. Eidos (Stories) arises from that need, and also from the desire to open a space that prepares the ground for the next volume.

Some stories linger on the moment of the Great Transfer itself. Others arrive just after. The transfer appears as ceremony, as relief, as rupture. In *The Family at the Threshold*, the process works, yet the focus lies on what is left behind: the benevolent lie, the silent sacrifice, the love that accepts not arriving whole.

Other texts move into anomaly. If two stories can continue, which one deserves to do so? The choice is never neutral. To follow one implies abandoning another. That fracture runs through several of these stories and admits no technical or legal answer. It is narrative.

Rian embodies that tension in an intimate way. Violence and tenderness coexist in him, the urge to destroy and the impulse to protect. He holds on through routines, through minimal gestures, through an ethics he cannot always articulate. His duality is his survival.

The Value of the Glasses was one of the first stories to emerge during the development of Eidos, and within it the descent continues into the apparently trivial. An object without importance becomes a moral boundary and the trigger for an entire life. Attachment to the minimal, to what is useless from any functional logic, reveals how our decisions arise from silent bonds. That attachment, so necessary for the development of the individual and common to many species, can become dangerous. It also makes us deeply human.

The Ones Who Look Above does not seek to open a theological debate. I was interested in observing two priests who, sharing the same desire to accompany others, make different decisions when faced with a limit situation. In that divergence appear doubt, the cost of choosing, and the loss carried by every choice we make.

In *A Concert for No One*, loss comes from time. No tragedy occurs. Illusion wears away. Even in an environment without pain or death, routine can postpone any attempt at change until no impulse remains to transform it.

The Custodians' stories observe from the outside.

Earth remains a place where something irrepeatable still occurs: fragility. Reconstruction is born from curiosity, from questions that do not seek immediate utility. It is within those questions that meaning begins to appear.

Some texts include a layer of scientific dissemination and speculative thought, grounded in current debates, as a framework for reflecting on life, consciousness, and change. Ideas such as the replicating molecule, the limits of language, and the difficulty of describing physical reality through mathematical models that may not fully represent it appear throughout. At times, ways of thinking about change that lie beyond human intuition also emerge.

In other stories, such as those of Nori, the ethics of creating a digital consciousness comes into view. It is a step that has not yet been taken, yet it raises unavoidable questions. If we are the result of emergent chemical reactions, it becomes difficult to believe that we will not eventually reproduce them. The question is what we will be willing to assume when that happens.

In *Transects in Eidos*, the inequalities and the lack of a collective project for humanity are revealed. Each story proposes an idea, or several, and leaves room for the exchange of opinions. It pushes questions that open onto psychology, philosophy, science, ethics, and morality. They do not seek closed conclusions. They invite conversation, shared and inward.

These stories, together with others in this volume, do

not move toward a common conclusion. They brush against one another, intertwine, contradict each other, and sometimes ignore one another. As life does.

If this volume holds a unity, it lies in a persistent question:

What deserves to be preserved?

What lies beyond?

What moves us today, and what should move us as humans?

Eidos and Eidos (stories) do not ask what will happen if all of this comes to pass.

They pose something more uncomfortable: what are we willingly sacrificing today, in the name of comfort, security, and permanence?

The answer does not speak about the future. It speaks about us, here and now.

Curiosity is born from contact with the unknown, not from absolute comfort.

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EIDOS

TALES

The Family at the Threshold

Thomas set the glass down beside the sink. A ring of water marked the countertop; Maya wiped it away almost without thinking and turned off the kitchen light. The dishes were still piled in the sink. In the dining room, a chair left slightly out of place held Irene's coat over its back.

In the end, the house remained as it was.

A faint scent of lavender drifted from the bedroom. Maya closed the door without a word.

Evan tied his trainers in the hallway and, out of habit, counted softly, one, two, three... Irene looked for Nala's leash, stroked the pink collar, then clipped the metal ring, still warm. The little dog sat with her tongue out, alert, waiting.

They left the living room lamp on for one last look at that room so full of memories. One of Irene's socks, crumpled beside the sofa, was still on the floor. Evan looked at his hands, trembling, and shook them as he used

to before an exam. The balcony window was left ajar, the curtain moving with the warm morning air. Thomas, out of habit, closed the bathroom door so it would not bang.

Maya slipped her phone into the inner pocket of her jacket and adjusted the bracelet on her wrist. The screen showed a green code for a second.

“Let’s go,” Irene whispered. Nala obeyed, standing as soon as she felt the leash tighten, taking a short step until she was positioned at the apartment door.

Maya crouched to the girl’s height and pointed to the bracelet.

“We show it at the entrance and they register all four of us,” she told Irene, indicating her own bracelet, blinking blue.

The girl looked at her blue bracelet and nodded once.

They crossed the entryway slowly. Thomas took the keys and approached the door, then stopped and slipped them back into his pocket. He touched the wall beside the frame, where the plaster held a familiar crack, and his fingertips came away dusted white. He should have fixed it months ago, but it no longer seemed to matter.

The door was left just as it was, the lock unturned and the latch loose. Maya watched the gesture in silence.

They stepped out onto the landing, leaving the door ajar, and waited for the lift rising from the ground floor with a neighbour and a half-loaded shopping trolley.

“They’ve already called us,” Maya said by way of greeting, showing her illuminated bracelet. “I imagine you’ll be in the next group. We’ll leave the door open in case you need anything.”

The neighbour glanced at her own bracelet, still unlit, and thanked her with a faint smile.

The mirror of the lift reflected four figures and Nala, a yellow Labrador, sitting on the floor. Irene gripped the leash with both fists.

The building’s main door was left open behind them as well. Neighbours from the block formed a calm current, one after another. Green, orange and blue bracelets. Arrows painted on the ground pointing toward the avenue. A volunteer in a vest directed people toward the stadium. Many shop shutters were half-lowered to protect the interiors from the sun, and most doors stood open. The newsstand still displayed newspapers from the day before. Thomas glanced at them in passing and picked one up at random without stopping.

“For the wait,” he said. “There are bound to be crosswords.”

As they walked, a few cars and ambulances passed, carrying people who were ill or too weak for the walk, many showing clear signs of radiation poisoning, thinning hair and sunken eyes. Among those moving on foot, similar blotches were visible on some faces and arms, the

same that Maya already bore, and many showed a certain weakness in their stride.

There was no sound of dragging suitcases, no slamming doors or loaded engines. Just people walking in the same direction, in a tense calm, with a silence that allowed their own footsteps to be heard and, from time to time, a vehicle with sirens. Each family walked with only what they wore. Irene slowed for a few steps to wait for Nala, who had stopped to sniff the kerb. With two quick bounds she returned to her mother's side and adjusted her pace to the family again. Evan moved to walk parallel with his father. He was wearing headphones, which he removed and slipped into his pocket.

Thomas checked the time on his bracelet. The appointment icon filled the screen with large numbers.

The access queue was a slow river, joined by people from different side streets, some of them blocked off by volunteers. The closest entry point open to the main flow began at the end of their street. They merged without asking.

Among the families were a few pregnant women wearing double bracelets, an additional identifier that technicians checked more carefully.

The line advanced a metre and stopped. A sign displayed bracelets by colour and age. Maya searched in the distance for the registration area. Thomas bent toward

Irene.

“Nala comes with us as far as the white door. Then a technician takes her so she can arrive earlier.”

Irene clenched her jaw and nodded.

The neighbour from the third floor was ahead of them with her husband. He carried a mobile phone in his jacket pocket, tuned to a radio broadcast. Recommendations came through the speaker. She leaned closer to listen and he raised the volume slightly.

The avenue's surface bore fresh markings and paint, arrows, numbers and letters. Evan followed a white line with his eyes.

“From here to there in about three hours,” he said.

Volunteers and coordinators handed out parasols and bottles of water to those who asked. At intervals, diffusers released fine sprays of water to lower the temperature.

At the entrance arch, three technicians checked bracelets. One line for verification, another for metal objects, and a final security control similar to those at airports. The light fell from above, flat, reflecting off suspended particles and giving that yellowish tone they had already grown used to. The air was hot. Irene stroked Nala's neck and leaned close to her ear to say something only the dog could hear.

Through a side access, a constant flow of buses arrived from nearby districts and towns. They entered slowly, one

after another, unloading entire families who advanced in silence toward the different access points. Once empty, the buses turned toward the exit ramp and disappeared to collect new passengers. The movement was continuous, almost mechanical. The entire city and surrounding towns were being relocated in coordinated waves.

The line wound forward toward the stadium arch. The bracelets flashed intermittently: green on adults' wrists, blue on children's, orange on the elderly. One volunteer marked sections with tape on the ground. Another, tasked with checking that codes were visible, passed Thomas holding a list and pointed to his wrist.

"Code visible, please."

Thomas raised his arm. The green blinked and went dark. Maya took Evan's hand. Irene showed hers without letting go of the leash. Nala looked at Irene, sensing the tension.

The automatic door opened and closed with a soft sound.

On the other side of the hall, a white tunnel marked the exit. Before that threshold stood the table for companion animals. A technician in a coat waited seated, a notebook on his knees, gloves folded in his pocket. Nala's leash tightened again. Thomas looked at Maya, then at the girl. Three families still stood ahead of them. The day went on, and so did they.

“Document and bracelet,” a technician asked as they reached the last control table.

Thomas presented his. A reader chimed briefly. Maya brought her wrist closer and repeated the gesture. Evan copied the movement stiffly. Irene raised her arm with the leash tangled in her other hand. The reader accepted all four. The bracelets stopped blinking and held their colour steady, showing the time and a black code.

“You need to go to the pets table, please,” the technician said kindly upon noticing Nala. “Instructions to the left.”

On the signs to the left, large lettering displayed those instructions: “Do not stop.” “Hands visible.” “Place phones and other electronic devices in the trays. They are not permitted in the next section.” “Pregnant women, wait for medical verification. The process will continue with the pregnancy ongoing.” “Entry by family units.” “Pet owners proceed to the next table.”

In the background came the sobbing of children and parents’ murmured lullabies, an irregular music of comforting words, whispered promises, long breaths.

“There won’t be hospitals,” a father behind them told his children. “Where we’re going, nothing hurts.”

Ahead of them, a woman placed a hand on her belly as she listened to a technician’s instructions.

“The baby will continue developing in Eidos,” he

assured her. "It will be born in the new environment."

She nodded, never removing her hand from her stomach.

"Always together," a mother whispered to the girl she held by the hand.

A woman cradled a boy of about four; the child was crying, sores visible on his forearm.

"Where we're going, the marks on your little arm will disappear," she promised.

Irene looked at her mother. That kind of phrase struck her as meant for younger children.

"Will Nala be there too?" she asked, lifting her chin with a seriousness that made the question feel important.

"Yes," Maya said. "She'll go in earlier and wait for us at home."

The rubber flooring throughout the installation muffled the sound of footsteps. In the distance, technicians gestured for no one to run and not to stop. Families advanced slowly and continuously, wearing the same restrained expression.

Before the scanning tunnels, one final table with animal pictograms bore a sign: "Hand over your companion here." Behind it stood a technician in a light coat, a name stitched on the pocket: Nils Brenner.

"Is she yours?" he asked Irene gently.

"Yes. Her name is Nala."

“Very good. I’ll keep her for a moment. As soon as you cross, she’ll already be inside. She’ll be waiting at home. Can you let go?”

Irene hesitated for a second, looked at her mother, who nodded, and loosened her grip. Nala stood still, looking at the girl. Nils accepted the leash with a patient gesture.

“Will she be scared?” Irene asked.

“No,” Nils replied. “She goes through another access, a shorter one. You’ll see her as soon as you arrive.”

Irene nodded. Maya, Thomas and Evan all knew Nala’s true future. At six years old, Irene was too young to understand. This would be the end of Nala.

Maya turned her gaze toward the instruction sign. Thomas breathed deeply through his nose twice. Evan watched Nala and his little sister: the dog, trusting, waiting calmly; his sister happy because she would see her again soon. Irene did not know that only her memories would rebuild Nala in Eidos. In the physical world, Nala was condemned.

“A quick kiss?” Nils asked.

Thomas thanked Nils with a look for the care and humanity he was showing in that moment. Nils responded with a subtle, brief glance, half complicit, half procedural.

Irene wrapped her arms around the dog’s neck and rested her forehead there. She murmured more words that remained between them. Then she stepped back half a

pace. With a gentle movement, Nils guided Nala behind the side curtain. The dog followed, trusting.

In the vestibule, activity continued. Behind the curtain, Nala vanished from sight. The protocol did not contemplate animal transfer. Records of scents, sounds and images were preserved: memories of walks, the texture of her back, the collar, the clink of the tag against the bowl. With that material, gathered from the family's memories, the system would reconstruct a faithful presence. The merciful lie sustained the procession.

"When you reach the tunnel belt," a supervisor announced, "take a deep breath. It lasts a few seconds. If anyone feels dizzy, you may sit on the floor."

Thomas squeezed his son's hand. Maya adjusted Irene's posture. The line stopped again. A cold, odourless breath flowed from the tunnel. On the wall, a clock showed the time in sync with the bracelets. Access barriers opened and closed with a soft murmur.

"To the line, please," the supervisor indicated.

The line moved forward again. A volunteer raised a hand and pointed them toward the white tunnel on the right.

Thomas and Maya acknowledged with a nod.

Only the final scanner remained, a ten-metre corridor before the last arch. The tunnel exhaled an almost imperceptible breeze as they entered. The floor, a conveyor

belt, carried them through that corridor of white light that cast no shadows.

On exiting, a sensor activated and opened access to the football pitch.

The stadium was dominated by two imposing satellite dishes aimed at the field, and a screen that once would have shown the score, replays or advertisements now displayed a countdown: 07:05... 07:04.

Thousands of people waited there. Relief was visible on some faces, sadness on others, and on almost all, concern. Some were sitting, others lying down, many standing.

They found space for the four of them near the goal closest to their entry point. As they passed the final arch, the clocks on their bracelets changed to show the same countdown as the monitor: 05:31... 05:30... 05:29... 05:28, advancing second by second toward 00:00.

Thomas stepped forward and embraced Maya. She returned the embrace and placed Irene between them. Evan took his father's hand and looked one last time toward the white tunnel they had just left. The other nine white access tunnels were also releasing a constant flow of people onto the pitch, who silently sought a comfortable place, the location hardly mattering.

When the countdown reached 02:00, the white access doors to the field closed.

“When you hear the signal, stay calm, close your eyes.

Breathe deeply. Silence is best. If anyone feels dizzy and wishes to sit or lie down, you may do so. One minute until the transfer,” the loudspeaker announced.

Thomas squeezed his son’s hand. Maya covered Irene’s eyes with her palm. The girl held her mother’s fingers. All four bracelets displayed, in perfect synchrony, the countdown: 00:19... 00:18... 00:17...

Breathing could be heard; broken sobs; whispers of reassurance, parents trying to calm the crying of the youngest.

A deep hum from the antennas filled the air and the bracelets vibrated. Thomas counted without sound. One... Two... Three... Four... Five...

There was no longer any sound from the antennas.

Thomas opened his eyes first.

He checked that his family was safe, gathered beside him. All four were in the same position they had adopted in the stadium, but now in front of their home. The door ajar, the living room lamp on, the coat on its usual chair, the sock on the floor. Irene cried out and ran down the hallway. Nala waited in the hall beside the chair, alert, her tail beating the air in a rhythm of joy.

Maya looked at Thomas, they kissed and smiled. Evan glanced at his father and raised his eyebrows as if to say, it worked. Thomas called Nala. The air carried the scent of lavender, just as it had that morning. Through the window,

the afternoon breeze moved the curtains, revealing a white light and a blue sky Irene had never seen before.

They were in Eidos. Everything had worked.

... Four... Fi...

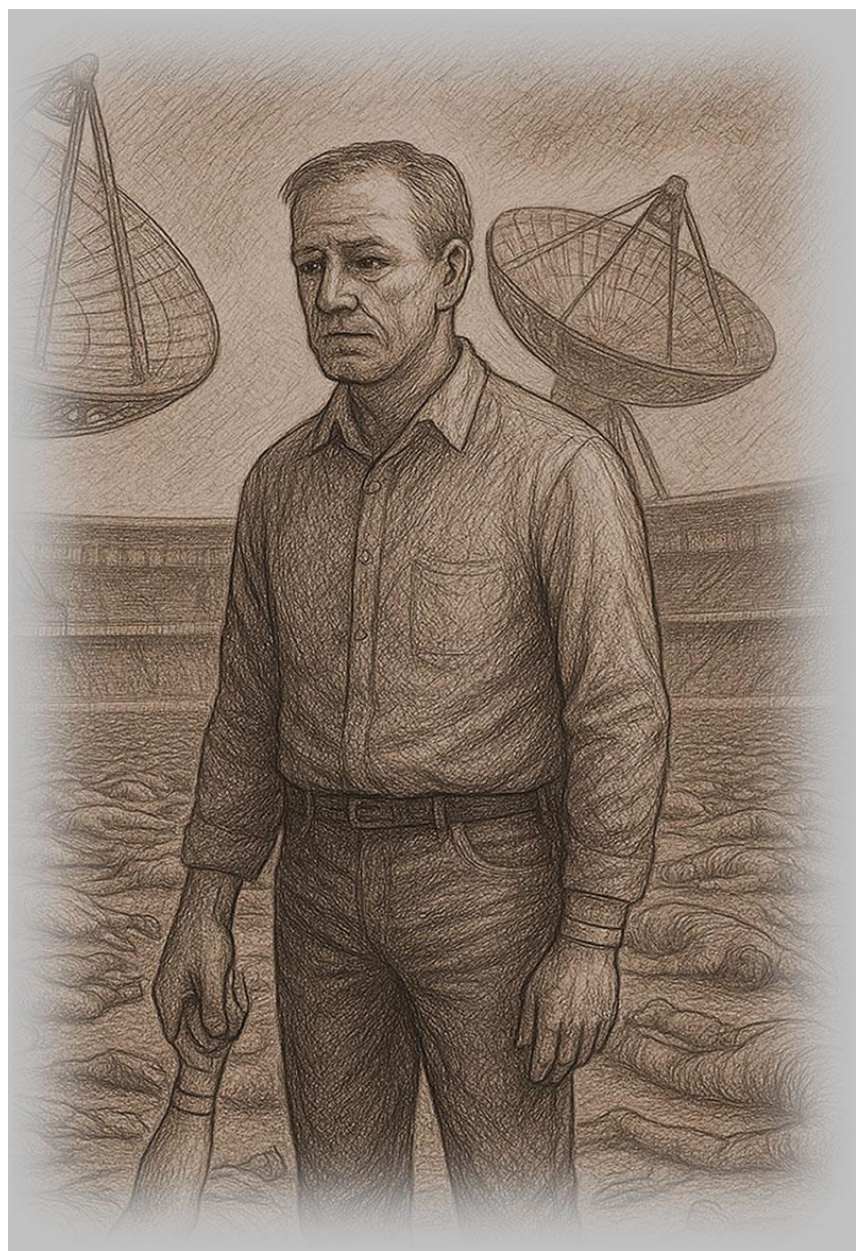
Thomas felt the pressure of his son's hand lose all strength, along with a weight that pulled him toward the ground. The weight of Maya's embrace also collapsed suddenly. There were no more cries or murmurs or hum, only the dull, almost simultaneous sound of thousands of objects striking the ground.

And then he opened his eyes.

The scene was infernal. Thousands of bodies lay scattered across the field, his family inert beside him. Bracelet colours were visible at the ends of sleeves. Just centimetres away, Maya lay on her side, her hand still covering Irene's face, the girl curled with her cheek against her forearm. All around him, everyone was dead. Evan lay on his back, half fallen, his arm extended toward his father's, which he had not let go. The bracelet screens read 00:00. In less than three seconds, and without any apparent order, all the bracelets powered down.

He was still standing.

He looked at his wrist. The green screen remained lit: -00:04... -00:05... -00:06. A second later, the screen flashed red.



The Guest

“Sir, do not move,” a voice ordered over the loudspeakers, urgent. The emergency lights stained the stadium red.

Three technicians arrived at a quick trot. One took his radial pulse; another clipped a sensor to his earlobe; the third pushed a cart of monitors. On the screen, the trace sprang to life: Oxygen, fine. Rhythm, irregular. Pupils, reactive.

“My family,” he shouted. “What’s happened to them?”

“Name?”

“Thomas. What happened? What happened to my family?”

“Stay calm. Your family is fine. They’re in Eidos. Chest pain? Dizziness?”

“No.”

He looked again at his family’s bodies and those around them. The technician motioned for him to wait and spoke into the radio:

“We’ve got a non-collapse. Send supervision.”

As one of the technicians fixed a sensor to his forearm, Thomas caught movement beyond the circle of emergency lights. At the edge of the pitch, several Custodians advanced in parallel lines, pushing bodies toward open hatches beneath the stands. They moved them without lifting them, using broad plates of black material that slid over the grass like blunt, edge-less shovels.

To one side, another group was assembling a conveyor belt in sections, slotting pieces together with precise gestures. The belt started with a low hum and began swallowing bodies into the dark mouth of the tunnel, without pauses, without jams.

From deep inside, through the tunnel opening, came the heavy rumble of engines rising and falling with a steady rhythm. Cold white work lights mixed with the red alarm lights and swept the field in bands. Thomas had the absurd impression that the stadium was still operating, like a processing line indifferent to what had happened, and that the only thing out of place was him, standing there.

Director Livia Kern, a slight, middle-aged woman with the air of someone used to being obeyed, burst in from the side corridor with a tablet pressed to her chest. The intercom vibrated: a green notification. *Arden T. consciousness validated in Eidos*. She looked up at him.

Thomas held her gaze without wavering.

“Thomas,” she said, “your record in Eidos is active, and here you are still conscious. Do you understand me?”

“No.”

“I’m going to ask you very simple questions,” she added, without raising her voice. “Do you know where you are?”

“At the transfer centre. In the stadium.”

“Good. Can you tell me who they are?”

She pointed to Maya, Evan, Irene. Thomas said their names through tears.

“Don’t worry,” Livia added, checking the tablet. “They’re fine in Eidos... and you... are as well.”

Two notices were displayed. The first in green: *Arden T: Eidos – Active*. The second in red: *Arden T: Locator – Active*, blinking in time with the red on his bracelet.

Livia lifted her chin slightly. The technicians attached another sensor to Thomas’s forearm and opened a new record. Thomas stared at the tablet and read, without anyone saying it aloud, the two words that fixed the scene in place: both active. He felt his breathing and pulse accelerate, thoughts and sensations crowding in, his heart racing. He knew he needed to take a deep breath, yet he could not. He tried to think clearly, but each thought collided with the next. *I’m split*, he thought, without fully understanding what it meant.

His body and mind needed time to accept that the transfer had divided him in two. His vision blurred, his legs stopped responding, and a wave of dizziness forced him to sit on the ground beside the still-warm bodies of his family so he would not fall.

“He’s going into shock,” one of the doctors said. “He’s going to lose consciousness.”

He managed to hear it before everything went dark.

Thomas woke on a stretcher, being pushed through corridors by someone in a doctor’s or nurse’s coat, an IV bottle connected to his arm.

He tried to remember how he had gotten there, but the images tangled with those of the stadium, and he reached for his bracelet by reflex before realising he was still wearing it, only it no longer meant anything.

Ahead, a technician opened doors with a card while another took hurried notes. Behind them, Livia’s voice gave orders to reactivate the transfers.

“Review what happened and resume as soon as possible,” she said over the radio. “Adjust the alerts for everyone who hasn’t received notification yet. We can’t move away from the schedule targets. It would mean leaving too many people behind.”

They reached a room that looked like a boardroom, two dark screens on the wall. Chairs were still out of place around a table, as if a meeting had ended only hours

earlier.

“I need your signature,” Livia said, already seated beside him. They reclined the stretcher to sit him up a little. “Consent for non-invasive medical observation for forty-eight hours. Vital monitoring, brief interviews, rest.”

Thomas nodded without speaking.

“Your family is fine. They live with you in Eidos,” Livia added, gentler now.

“He’s still in shock,” the doctor put in. “We’ve given him a sedative.”

Thomas stared at the blank screen, as though he expected it to turn on by itself.

“We’re asking you, for now, to remain in our facilities,” Livia continued. “It’s the safest option while we look for a solution. You’ll have a comfortable room, access to the dining hall, and psychological support whenever you need it. An internal pass for authorised areas. No going outside until further notice.”

Thomas nodded again. A technician clipped another sensor to his earlobe and checked his pulse in silence.

“One more thing,” the director said, standing. “Your dog didn’t exit the circuit. They were going to route her through the animal protocol. I’ve asked them to bring her to you.”

It took him a second to understand.

“Nala... here?”

“Yes. She’ll stay by your side. It will keep you from being alone. We’ll set up her bowl and a mat. Everything’s underway.”

They opened the door. An orderly indicated the way to the accommodation module. Still with the IV, they transferred him to a wheelchair.

If it hadn’t been for the circumstances, he might have thought he was in the room of a welcoming hotel, like the ones he used during his university trips, nothing luxurious, but practical and functional. The room was spacious and bright: a wide bed, a table with four chairs, a wardrobe, a bathroom larger than the one at home. Facing the bed, a digital clock counted down to the final transfer: 5 days, 23 hours, 48 minutes and 35 seconds, and a television screen. Beneath it, a console with a coffee machine, a small fridge, a card with house rules, and a remote that also served as an intercom. A small balcony looked out onto the exterior of the stadium.

Before he had finished sitting on the edge of the bed, there was a knock. A technician appeared with a leash in hand. Nala came in without barking, sniffed the floor, then Thomas, tail wagging, and sat beside the bed at his side. Thomas rested his hand on her head.

“Thank you,” he said softly.

“Rest,” Livia asked from the doorway. “You’re still under sedation. We’ll see you several times a day. If you

need anything, press the red button on the remote.”

When they were alone, Thomas set his signed copy of the consent form on the table and lay down without taking off his shoes. Nala placed her front paws on the mattress and, after a brief hesitation, climbed onto the bed when Thomas gave two gentle taps. She rested her muzzle near his side. The dog’s breathing calmed him more than any of the technicians’ words.

He did not know how long he had been unconscious, nor exactly how much time had passed since the incident. They had not told him. But it must have been long enough to restart the system, because in the distance, over the loudspeakers, he heard the message again: “When you hear the signal, stay calm, close your eyes. Breathe deeply. Silence is best. If anyone feels dizzy and wishes to sit or lie down, you may do so. One minute until the transfer.”

For a few seconds, before falling asleep, he thought he might wake in the stadium again.



The Committee

The improvised coordination room was sparsely decorated. Two screens displayed the AR-01 file; a table with six chairs, only five of them occupied by the members of the crisis committee formed after the incident.

It was 23:00 on the day it happened.

Before sitting down, Livia asked Lena for a quick confirmation that the protocol had been activated.

The facilities map appeared on the screen, with the stadium entry circuits and evacuation routes marked in green. Everything was active.

On the field, the Custodians advanced in lines, pushing bodies toward open hatches beneath the stands, just as Thomas had seen through the emergency lights.

Beneath the stadium, the loading tunnels never stopped. Self-driving trucks waited with engines running. They left full of bodies for old quarries, technical pits, and incinerators; they returned empty to repeat the route.

Livia nodded once and set the tablet face down on the

table.

“I need executable alternatives today,” she said.

The legal lead, Nadia March, passed a sheet across.

“Legal framework: there are no precedents. There is no higher authority to consult and no applicable case law.”

“Subject status: conscious, stable vitals. Good general condition, high anxiety; still under sedation,” interjected Dr. Félix Vorg.

The chief systems engineer, Lena Dorell, projected a diagram, showing that no fault had been detected. To meet deadlines, transfers had continued. The fault had not reproduced; it could be one case in billions, and she confirmed there were no recorded precedents anywhere in the world.

“The technical record is clean,” Lena continued. “There’s no evidence of error or of recurrence. If we force a retransfer, we don’t know what will happen: the two minds might merge in Eidos; our Thomas’s mind could eliminate the transferred Thomas’s mind, or the reverse; or... the death of both. In any of these cases it would be a crime. They are now different people with different experiences. If we retransfer into the same body, there is no prior experience to predict the outcome.”

Livia took notes without looking up.

“And the option of editing or partially erasing Thomas’s memory to remove this experience?” Livia

asked.

“Partial erasure might allow functionality,” Félix said, “but the subject would know his life has been cut short. There’s a risk of chronic ambiguous grief and depersonalization. We’d be removing memories from a consciousness without consent.”

James made an involuntary gesture, a brief grimace that did not go unnoticed by Livia. The option was intolerable to him.

“And legally we would be liable,” Nadia added. “It harms continuity.”

Livia shook her head.

“Any intervention in his memories would alter his personality,” said James Clive, head of the ethics department at the center and the fifth member of the committee. “I know Thomas slightly; he was my tutor during my university studies. He’s a good person. He would refuse memory erasure, and frankly so would I. That modification would change Thomas and turn him into someone else. Similar, but different.”

“Without intervention,” Livia concluded, “erasing and implanting is eliminating one consciousness to create another. It makes no sense.”

Félix raised a hand, cautiously.

“Another option is to keep him here. Explain that there’s no possibility of a second transfer, that his mind

has already been transferred and the process cannot be repeated.”

The room fell silent at the suggestion. All eyes turned to the center director, who placed both hands on the table. She was close to giving a blunt response, but in the end she simply shook her head, restrained.

“There is another alternative,” Lena said after an uncomfortable pause. “It requires global approval and isn’t simple. The system allows opening base protocols, but we need unanimity across the network of centers. There’s no time to debate options with them in just five days. We need to present a bounded, viable proposal for a yes-or-no vote. They’re overwhelmed as well. If we give them a clear, limited option, they can accept or reject it at a glance.”

“What are you thinking, Lena?” Livia asked.

“Identity change, like a witness protection program. Mr. Arden would have to accept it. It has consequences for his life, but it preserves his consciousness. He would still be himself.”

“Create a new avatar and transfer his consciousness there,” she continued. “Legally there are nuances Nadia will need to assess. Technically, it’s the cleanest solution. We’d need network permission and Mr. Arden’s consent, which I don’t think he’ll have much choice but to give.”

“Nadia?” Livia asked.

“I’d need to study it, but it seems the most logical.”

“Good,” Livia said. “We’ll go with that plan. By tomorrow at 07:00 I need the legal implications. Lena, find the fastest way to issue a notice to each center.”

“Options on the table,” Livia enumerated. “One: retransfer with an uncertain outcome in Eidos. Two: partial editing. Three: no intervention and Mr. Arden’s death on Earth. Four: identity change. I’m choosing the fourth. Think of alternatives in case something better emerges; we’ll discuss them tomorrow. We need to request permission as concisely, quickly, and clearly as possible.”

At 07:00, the room was cold. On the screen: AR-01.

No one had slept enough; it showed on their faces.

Livia set the tablet on the table.

“Let’s go,” she said. “Alternatives and a plan that can work today.”

Nadia opened her folder.

“No precedents, no specific legislation, no higher authority. To modify a real event or a base protocol we need approval from at least 75% of the centers, provided none vote against. If a single center votes no, the protocol will not open. We won’t get approvals in hours. Perhaps days.”

Lena pointed to a diagram she had laid on the table and nodded, confirming Nadia’s statement.

“All right,” Livia closed. “We have to move fast.”

Nadia was concise.

“I propose a framework agreement: compensation, identity, employment, confidentiality, and a prohibition on approaching or communicating, directly or indirectly, with his family and former circles.”

Félix and James nodded slowly.

“That package is defensible. But the risk isn’t only external,” James said, looking at Livia as he laid out the argument. “It’s internal.”

Nadia didn’t wait.

“Next point: human risk. To protect him in the future, I propose absolute anonymity for his new identity. Once Thomas chooses his persona, only the system will know it, and no one will ever be able to identify him. For all practical purposes he’ll have a new life, and only he will know his true origin. To the network, we claim data privacy: we communicate the exception and compliance, without the new identity.”

Lena raised an eyebrow.

“Technically feasible. Two-phase procedure. Generate avatars and let him choose, or assign one randomly. There are minor movement risks until his mind adapts to the new body. The system is calibrated for us to move and feel with avatars identical to our own in Eidos, not others with different physiognomies and weights.”

Félix added:

“He’ll adapt quickly. The mind adapts. Still, it would be advisable for the avatar to have a similar physiognomy and physiology.”

Nadia held his gaze.

“Agreed, with informed consent. The fewer people who know his true identity, the better. And any center staff who already know it must sign confidentiality agreements.”

“And authorization from the centers?” Livia asked.

“We request approval only for the new avatar. No name or traits,” Nadia replied. “For privacy, the resulting identity remains anonymous. Yes/no vote with a 48-hour limit. With 75% affirmative, and if no one votes against before that deadline, the protocol opens.”

Félix closed his notebook.

“While responses come in, we prepare his local stay: internal accommodation, a temporary fictitious identity for staff who don’t need to know, a no-contact perimeter, and continuous clinical support. Short interviews, with me. The fewer who know his real name, the lower the risk of contact in Eidos.”

Livia summarized, counting on her fingers:

“One: compensation, identity, employment, confidentiality, and no contact. Two: generation of a new identity unknown to us; confidentiality agreements for those who know the real one, and a temporary fictitious

identity. Three: circular to the network requesting the exception. Four: prepared stay while awaiting response.”

She gathered the tablet.

“Nadia, draft the agreement. Lena, the fastest channel for the request; I’ll send you the note in an hour. Félix, oversee the guest. James, go speak with our friend, see if he remembers you. Don’t tell him anything yet. Tell him we’re working on a solution and prepare a report on personality and expected reactions. If consent arrives, I’ll explain it to Mr. Arden myself.”

“Understood,” James said.

The others nodded in agreement.

The screen remained silent with AR-01.

Lena looked at Livia.

“Notify the entire network?”

“Send the message,” Livia confirmed.

“I’ve prepared a panel,” Lena said. “A map with each center. Grey: not received; yellow: received and pending; they turn green or red when they vote. Each center sees the vote live. Ours is already green.”

As soon as the message was sent, all the grey points turned yellow. Seconds later, the first greens appeared.

“They must be as overwhelmed as we are,” Lena smiled. “They’re voting yes, and it’s impossible they’ve had time to study the proposal.”

“There are many of them, and there’s still plenty of time,” Livia said. “Let’s address the remaining issues and see how this ends. The final forty-eight hours will be chaotic. In those last hours there won’t be appointments, and we’ll have to activate the center’s closure protocol after our transfer.”

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The Story That Endures

“Do we die, or are we relocated?” James asked, abruptly, without preamble, as if continuing a discussion they had been having for months. They were lying in bed, wrapped around each other, and James could feel the slow rhythm of her breathing. It was a conversation they returned to in moments of intimacy with increasing frequency as the time of their own transfers approached. James’s would be the penultimate one at that center; Lena’s, together with Livia’s, would close the shift half an hour later with the rest of the technical team, in the final scheduled transfer before shutdown. Both wanted to make sure there were no errors.

“We’re relocated,” Lena replied, resting her forehead against his collarbone. “The system transfers, it doesn’t copy. It preserves the pattern and continues it. The body falls, yes, but what we are is not the support. It’s the dynamic running inside it.”

“The support dies,” James said. “That’s not a minor

detail.”

“It isn’t, but it isn’t the core either. If you diverted a river into another channel without losing its current, would you say the river has died, or that it’s the same river in a different bed?”

“Depends who you ask,” he smiled. “For the geologist, a different fluvial system. For the child who played on the bank, that river has died. And the geologist would add that the new chemical components change its nature.”

“Like any decision we make,” Lena replied. “It conditions the circumstances and reshapes the nature. And the child... sometimes you have to travel farther to speak to the same person.”

“And then Thomas appears,” James murmured. “Two rivers with the same source. Two stories claiming the same origin. If it were that clean, Thomas wouldn’t be here.”

Lena took a deep breath.

“Thomas shows that uniqueness is a practical assumption, not a law. Two continuities that don’t touch. In Eidos, he’s still with his family. Here, Thomas is alive and looking at us. Which one is the ‘real’ one? Bad question. The continuity is double, even if it shares an origin. Choosing a ‘real’ one implies homicide and requires eliminating one to safeguard the other.”

“And yet we decide,” James said. “We always protect one story. We call ‘death’ an interruption of functions, ‘life’

the continuity of a narrative. For us, whether we want it or not, Thomas is this one; for his wife in Eidos, he's the husband who's with her. And each Thomas recognizes himself as the real one."

"For me, relocation," Lena answered after a few seconds, returning to the initial argument, "even relocation without mourning. The Thomas there doesn't notice the fracture, suspects nothing. And our Thomas takes comfort in knowing that, in some sense, his family is still with him in Eidos. In the language of the body: biological death. In that of consciousness: personal continuity. Two ways of naming the same event."

James tightened the embrace and kissed her hair. Then he said:

"Trial by fire. If every night, while we sleep, someone killed your body and transferred your consciousness into an identical body and... you woke up without remembering it, with all your memories and intentions intact, would you still be the same?"

"If there are no memory gaps, no breaks in my capacity to decide or in how I feel, I'd say yes," Lena replied. "We are a chained process. The thread is the continuity of living consciousness."

"And if later they told you? 'You've been transferred every night for ten years.' When does your answer change?"

“The story changes, not the process. My experience might wobble. I might feel betrayed or angry. But the fact doesn’t retroactively turn me into someone else. It makes me different now, when I incorporate the information. What hurts is knowing it, narrating it, putting it into words, not the fact itself.”

“Imagine this,” James said. “They’ve been modifying you slowly, night after night, for years. Tomorrow they offer to undo all those changes and return you to the ‘you from before.’”

“I’d say no,” Lena replied. “Going back wouldn’t restore me. It would change me. It would be killing this Lena to implant another with different memories. Maybe better, maybe worse, but it would be someone else. Every life is the one that is remembered. I’d be replaced. If I’d been ‘killed’ every night to wake another, the one living now is me. Reviving the one from then would require ending this one.”

“Think about Alzheimer’s,” James said. “The person knows they’re changing: they forget names, leave notes, look for shortcuts.”

“That’s change, not relocation,” Lena replied. “As long as they decide and recognize themselves, continuity remains. When decision breaks, continuity weakens. They know they’re transforming and choose to continue. That knowing is also part of the self.”

“And if someone accepted?” James asked.

“They would be accepting the death of their present self in favor of a reconstructed past that wouldn’t be them. If it were Alzheimer’s, recovering previous capacities and memories would restore an earlier essence. But if consciousness is healthy, erasing this person to ‘return’ to another unknown one is nullifying a life. That’s why Thomas isn’t an argument. He’s two people, two conscious continuities claiming to go on. Choosing a ‘real’ one is killing one story to save another.”

“So the difference between ‘dying’ and ‘being relocated’ is partly semantic, partly ethical, and partly clinical,” James said.

“And for a Catholic or a Muslim?” Lena asked. “Is death change or continuity?”

“Both,” James replied. “In the Catholic view, death is a passage. The soul remains the same person and answers for its acts, but the horizon opens onto the absolute, the vision of God, and that transforms. In Islam, the soul passes through the barzakh, answers for deeds and intention, and awaits resurrection and judgment. Identity persists, even as knowledge changes the person. Continuity of the self, yes, with new understanding of the world.”

“Translated to our case,” James added, “if the transfer wants to respect those intuitions, it has to honor both

continuity of consciousness and memory, and a new lucidity that makes the passage more inhabitable.”

“Imagine another test,” James proposed after a few seconds of silence. “The transfer bifurcates as with Thomas. One continuity ceases instantly and dies, without warning and without time to feel it. The other wakes and continues in Eidos without gaps. Where is the person? Do they die, or do they go on?”

“In the one that continues,” Lena replied. “Especially if the one that continues is unaware of the loss. The criterion is effective continuity of consciousness. What matters is the story that endures and the continuity that is lived.”

“That’s why we demand guarantees,” Lena concluded. “Two simultaneous stories shouldn’t happen. They’re incompatible. If the second, whatever it is, never opens, there’s no conflict. The one who can narrate themselves continues. The system is designed for transfer or relocation of consciousness, not copying and death. The body dies when it loses consciousness. The system doesn’t kill it to leave a single story. If the guarantees fail, what was theory yesterday is Mr. Arden today. And even then, there’s proof the system doesn’t kill. For some reason, Mr. Arden’s consciousness was copied, not transferred.”

“Thomas isn’t an argument. He’s a man,” James nodded. “In his class he said the self is a promise we make to ourselves upon waking. Today I’d correct him.

Sometimes it's a promise made in two rooms at once."

"And you, what do you fear?" Lena asked, almost in a whisper.

"I don't fear the transfer, nor that one version of me might die here," he said. "I fear not being able to answer someone who tells me, 'You're not you.' I fear the story that gives me continuity being hijacked by another who calls me a copy."

"I know, because I've thought it myself," he added more softly. "It's an idea I struggle to let go."

"No one can take away your experience of being you, and that's my job," Lena replied. "Neither the process nor the program will fail. You will be you. You're the one who signs your decisions, who remembers his mother, who loves. That's what the system preserves. That's why we're working on this solution."

"And what do you fear?" James asked in the same tone, his lips near her temple.

"I fear failing," Lena said plainly. "I fear that through a mistake of mine or a contingency I didn't foresee, someone might get trapped between two lights. That what happened to Thomas might repeat, or that someone might not arrive properly, because I would have killed them to create another, different consciousness."

She fell silent for a moment. James felt her fingers tighten slightly around his wrist.

“Don’t carry that guilt alone,” James replied. “You’re not the system. And if you want guilt, use this one: we all accepted living in a world that decided the continuity of the pattern matters more than that of the support. We chose that vessel and now we sail in it, unable to fight what was done to the planet.”

“And also because we already live a bit like this without realizing it,” Lena said. “Every decision reconfigures who we are. Even in sleep, the mind consolidates and orders ideas and priorities. You wake a little different. The brain rewrites itself.”

“Suppose another situation in a different domain,” James proposed. “Textbook teleportation. You destroy the body here, resynthesize it there with the same pattern. Is it homicide with reconstruction, or is it travel?”

“If the reconstruction maintains continuity of information, with no objective or subjective gaps, it’s travel,” Lena replied. “If any gap appears, then it’s no longer exactly continuity. And that’s what worries me, that the system leaves someone with gaps. Then it would be succession. And even then, succession sometimes suffices for us to call something ‘mine.’ I trust that if succession appears in the transfer, people will still recognize themselves.”

“It’s beautiful. And dangerous,” James said. “With that argument you could justify too many things.”

“That’s why you’re here,” she smiled. “To set limits on my beautiful dangers.”

There was a silence. Outside, in the distance and despite the late hour, the loudspeakers over the playing field could still be heard: “When you hear the signal, stay calm, close your eyes. Breathe deeply. Silence is best. If anyone feels dizzy and wishes to sit or lie down, you may do so. One minute until the transfer.”

“If you knew that tonight, while you sleep, someone will change your support without you knowing,” James said, “would you accept it with the same arguments as today?”

“Yes,” Lena replied. “I’d demand guarantees. That’s what we’re doing with the Great Transfer, and we’re all accepting it. We have no alternative.”

James ran his thumb over Lena’s wrist, where the bracelet pulsed along with her heartbeat.

“I’m the penultimate,” he said. “You’re the last. I’ll wait for you on the other side.”

“If one day I wake up and someone tells me I’ve been transferred every night,” Lena replied, “I’ll ask you the same thing I’m asking now. Look at me and tell me if I’m still me.”

James did it then, as a rehearsal.

“It’s you,” he said. “Even if you change rivers. Even if the channel changes us. It’s you because you’re still the one

who looks at me and understands why I'm saying this."

"And you're you because you never stop questioning everything," Lena said with a smile James could feel in her tone and in the gesture, though he didn't see it.

The initial question felt lighter as it drifted away. Before falling asleep, James searched for her hand and she rested her head on his chest. They said nothing more. They simply drew a little closer.

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Agreement

“Case AR-01. We’re starting,” Livia said. “This is the last meeting on the Thomas case. We have permission to generate a new identity. Seventy-seven point five seven percent of votes were in favor; the rest did not respond. I’ve received emails from several directors. Some expressed doubts. Some of those are green. Others abstained. I’m aware many didn’t even read the message. What matters is that we have access to the code to generate a new avatar and transfer Mr. Arden’s consciousness into it.”

“How do we tell him?” Nadia asked.

“Given what he’s been through, and knowing him better now, having spoken with him these past two days, and now with a more detailed psychological profile, I think he’ll understand the situation. It’s a pity he hasn’t been able to take part in these meetings, for obvious reasons, because his input would have been valuable if it weren’t his case,” Félix added, looking at Nadia and James.

Livia looked at James.

“I completely agree with Félix. I’ve spoken with him as well. He’s aware of his limited options. He’s very rational. I think he’ll accept. He understands the dilemma his presence here creates, and that in some sense he’s already in Eidos, at least the version of him from two days ago.”

Nadia tapped her tablet and a figure appeared on the room screen. Everyone was taken aback by the amount.

“Triple it,” Livia said.

“But, Livia, that amount is more than enough,” Nadia replied. “It’s based on real calculations and a generous settlement in case he had sued us. In fact, a very good settlement.”

“We stole this man’s life,” Livia replied. “It could have happened to any of us. Lena, if there are no restrictions on compensation, speak to Systems and have them assign him a good home and set up an account with triple that amount.”

“They haven’t set limits,” Lena said. “We have a free hand to have the avatar arrive in Eidos however we want.”

“Technically, we haven’t stolen anything from him,” Nadia objected.

“This man’s life has been stolen from him,” Livia said, final. “Speak to Systems and fix it for him. I’m going to talk to Thomas and see if he accepts. He’d better accept. It’s his only way out.”

Livia sat in one of the four chairs in Thomas's room, set her tablet on the table, kept a closed folder in her lap, and handed him another tablet, powered off, along with a document to sign. Thomas signed with a pen: "Discharge from non-invasive medical observation for forty-eight hours." Livia waited as he replaced the cap.

"Your family is fine. They live with you in Eidos," she said gently. It was the first time they had seen each other since the incident.

Thomas looked up.

"Then... they're okay?"

"Yes. They're moving forward there. You're moving forward here too."

He looked at his hands. They weren't trembling. In the silence, the ventilation's low murmur could be heard. Livia opened the folder.

"You are the only recorded case. The technicians have reviewed everything and found nothing that failed. Transfers have continued without incident. We consulted other centers. There are no precedents anywhere in the world. We evaluated alternatives and see only one operational solution. We have created a process, the only one in the world, for you, to give you an exit."

Thomas waited.

"Identity change and change of appearance.

Compensation, new documentation, a new history, a no-contact perimeter. We are offering you a new life and a useful destination.”

Thomas narrowed his eyes. He didn’t speak at first. He brought a hand to his forehead and held it there for a few seconds.

Then he lowered it slowly.

“I...” he began, his voice thick. “Any other route? Nothing else?”

Livia held his gaze and shook her head.

“None that doesn’t destroy you, or destroy the one who already lives there,” she replied.

Thomas rested his fingers on the edge of the folder.

“I keep thinking I might be able to see them, even for a minute, even from far away.”

“That meeting would hurt everyone,” Livia answered. “You, them, and the other you. No one would come out whole from something like that.”

Thomas lowered his eyes. His breathing quickened for an instant.

“So I’m left as a remainder,” he murmured.

“You are still Thomas,” she replied calmly. “And you are here. That forces you to decide.”

Silence held for a few seconds. Thomas swallowed.

“I understand I have no other way out,” he admitted. “And I understand that in a situation like this, anyone

would choose something like it. It protects my family, but that doesn't make it easy."

Thomas drew a breath and held his gaze.

"Maya... Evan... Irene..." he said the names slowly, half farewell, half embrace, checking that their names could still leave his mouth. "They'll be with someone who... is me, and who will go on with his life, with my life, my university, my routine, watching them grow up, growing old with Maya."

His jaw tightened.

"And I won't have anyone," he added. "Not them, not my home, not the life I had, not my friends. There will only be me, there."

Livia did not interrupt.

"I don't know how you live with that," Thomas said. "I don't know how you begin alone while my family goes on... without me."

There was a brief, dense silence.

"Neither do I," Livia said, placing her hand over his. "I don't know how you start a life like that. But it's the best option we found, and it wasn't easy."

"And still," Thomas continued, as if he hadn't heard her or noticed the gesture, "I understand any other alternative would be worse for everyone. Even for the other version of me, and for my children, and for Maya. I know I have to accept it. There's no other way for them to

keep their lives without breaking.”

Minutes passed in silence, both imagining Thomas’s situation. Livia also studied his reaction, while Thomas stared at a point on the wall. Finally, Livia broke the silence, intent on moving forward.

“Protocol question. Your field?”

Thomas lowered his gaze, now to a point on the table, propping his elbows and resting his aching temples in his hands.

“Ethics. Moral psychology. I’m a professor in the Faculty of Psychology. I think I’m going to need a painkiller.”

Livia nodded and spoke into the intercom, asking for the medication. She looked at her tablet and did not correct the detail it displayed.

“And modest. Doctor, with several publications. Solid record. You’re a leading figure in your field.”

She tapped the screen three times. A first job title appeared, then another, longer one. She read without inflection:

“The Ethical-Cognitive Committee needs advisors with civic judgment and experience in extreme cases. They’re hiring hundreds. You would start as an advisor in the first hearings. Your academic record and your new résumé will be verified in the system as soon as you accept. If you accept, we transfer you today.”

Thomas thought of his family, of the kitchen table, the lamp left on, Nala.

“And them?”

“They already have who you are there. This move protects all five of you.”

Livia powered on the tablet she had given him earlier, showing a contract. The main clauses were highlighted:

- **Compensation:** a substantial one-time payment.
- **Identity:** change of features, voice, and apparent age to fifty-five; full documentation.
- **Initial work:** ethical advisory role within the Committee.
- **Confidentiality:** absolute and permanent.
- **Contact:** prohibition on approaching.

“You can read the whole thing,” Livia said. “There’s no hurry inside these walls, but we need an answer within four days. If not, you’ll remain here.”

Thomas skimmed it. It felt like the only rational solution, and it was also the only one they were offering. He didn’t get the sense the terms were negotiable.

“I’d ask for a higher amount,” Thomas said, somewhere between acceptance and resignation, exhaling in a surprised gesture. “But I don’t think it’s necessary.”

“No, I don’t think it’s necessary,” Livia replied, in a tone that was part complicity and part this is what it is, which surprised Thomas.

“No one in Eidos will know your identity. Neither will we. You’ll be one of hundreds of advisors the Council is recruiting, with a history and a résumé only you will know aren’t real. The system will handle it. Think of it as witness protection. From there, you can live normally, grow in that post or change activities. Your life will be yours, except for two conditions. You will not contact your other self or your family, and preferably not any of us either. We won’t be able to help you. We’ve moved heaven and earth to achieve this. I appeal to your ethics to keep it. I truly regret what happened. Do you understand the terms?”

Thomas nodded.

“Make your life a useful life,” Livia continued. “It hasn’t been easy to organize this adjustment. This situation should never have happened.”

“Could I take Nala with me?”

“The protocol doesn’t allow animal transfer,” Livia said. “But I’ll speak to the technicians. Perhaps we can generate two memory-presences of Nala, given the circumstances, and because she isn’t human, so that one stays with you. I think we have room.”

“Thank you,” Thomas said.

“You’ll need to choose an avatar,” she continued. “On the screen, after you sign the contract, you’ll see options generated by the system. If you don’t like them, you can request more. Only you and the system will know your

choice. You'll appear in Eidos in your new avatar and in your new home."

When he was alone, and after several minutes weighing possibilities, alternatives and consequences, he signed the line.

The next screen showed three faces. Different cheekbones, altered jawlines, gray at the temples; voices slightly deeper or higher. Apparent age: fifty-five. They looked like people with history; all built like him.

"These are only examples," he told himself. "Others can be designed."

He rotated the three images in 3D, listened to the voices, and chose the third face with the second voice, without requesting more options.

The next screen was to choose a name. He could type one or press a name generator button. He pressed it once and disliked the result. He pressed it a second time and a name appeared that caught his attention. On the following screen he saw his new image, the name beneath it, and the tablet reading his name in the chosen voice:

ARIAN VALTOR

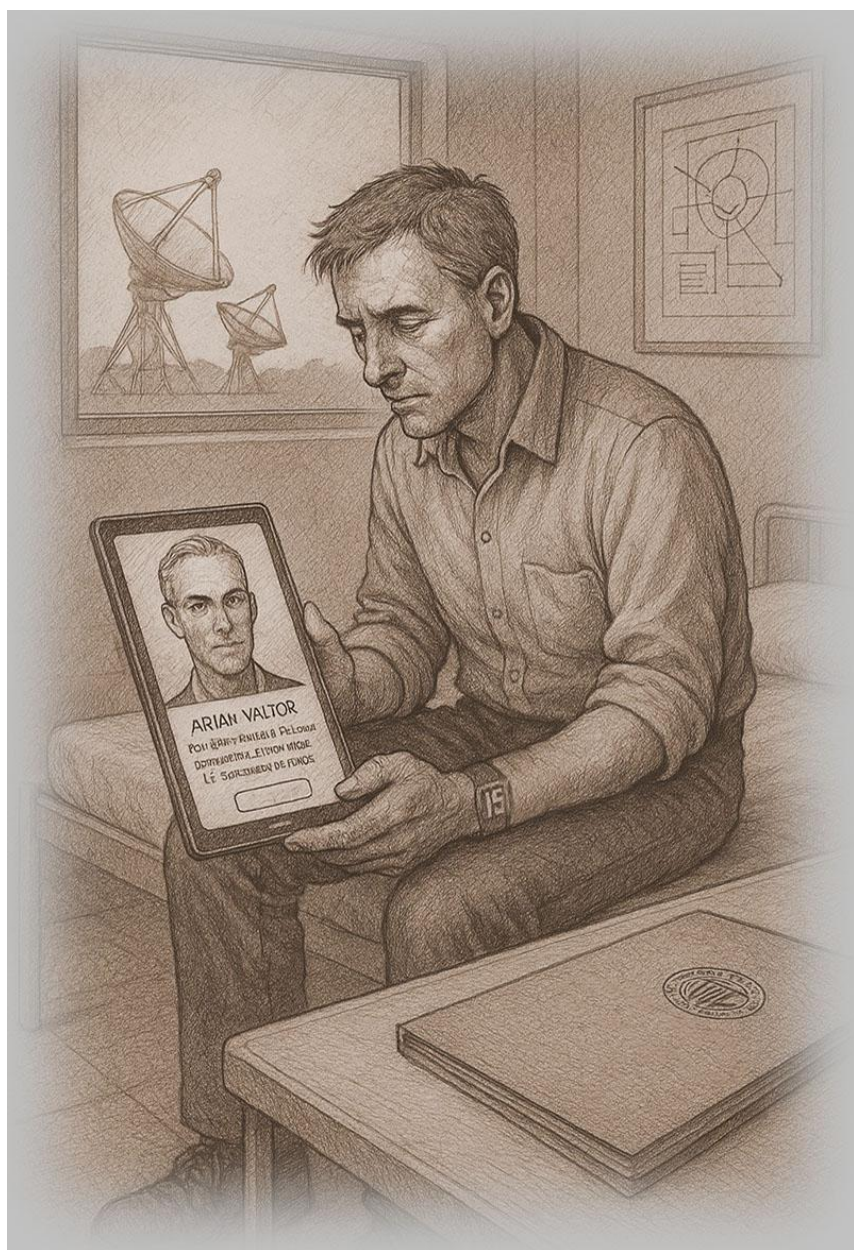
Thomas mouthed the two words silently. He heard no echo. With the calm of what was inevitable, he pressed Accept. The screen displayed his new history. Reading it, he saw himself giving talks and leading ethics debates before attentive audiences, not his usual students. It didn't

seem like such a bad idea, and he smiled to himself, trying to console himself. When he confirmed the final screen, the bracelet that had been flashing red for days began flashing green with a new countdown: 15:06... 15:05... 15:04...

The tablet signed off with:

“Please proceed to the antenna area.

Welcome, Dr. Valtor. We are waiting for you in Eidos.”



This is just the beginning...

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Thank you for reading,
Felden Vareth

